



a thousand words. It's rather painful and annoying to first take a screenshot, then upload it somewhere and then send a link – or send it in an email in parallel to the chat conversation.

The 'Send Screenshot' plug-in is very handy in this regard. It makes sending screenshots a breeze by integrating the screenshot and remote upload capabilities into Pidgin itself. All you need to do is click the screenshot option and it will let you select the area to shoot. It will then automatically upload the screenshot – you can select from a number of providers or upload it to your own FTP server – and paste the link in the chat window. Download the Send Screenshot plug-in from <http://code.google.com/p/pidgin-sendscreenshot/>

Eliminate typos

If you tend to make a lot of mistakes while chatting (don't worry we all do) the 'Text Replacement' plug-in can save you from yourself. This useful plug-in lets you enter a list of



Assign words to replace as you type

spelling (or other) mistakes and corrections, and automatically performs the replacement as you type.

This might seem like a pain, but it actually already comes with a huge list of common mistakes, such as typing 'teh' instead of 'the' 'i snot' instead of 'is not'. It also thankfully corrects abbreviations such

as 'ur' for 'you are' and 'cuz' for 'because'.

Of course, this can make it annoying if you really need to type something that's commonly a misspelling for another word.

This plug-in is included with Pidgin by default, but is not turned on.

Record your chat history

Pidgin also includes support for recording your chat history, and if you want, you can enable a plug-in that will show recent chat messages when you start a conversation with someone.

While Gmail already records all your chat conversations, it also lets you turn off recording chat messages if any one of the chatting parties so wishes. Pidgin on the other hand records all chat messages, even from those who are "Off the record" on Gmail.

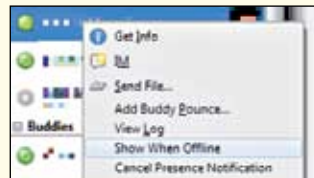
You can find these chat messages – and back them up if you want – at the following location: %appdata%\purple\logs\

There'll be a separate folder for each protocol (Gtalk and Facebook are 'jabber'). Within that is a separate folder for each account using that protocol, and within that a separate folder for each contact they've communicated with. The logs are simple HTML files that can be opened in any browser.

Show some offline users

You all might know some people who prefer to stay "invisible". It can be difficult starting a chat conversation with such people since they're usually listed as offline. So you either need to display all contacts, offline and online and hunt for these

people in a long list, or you need to manually start a chat conversation by entering their email (autocomplete helps here).



Invisible no more

And then you have a third option. You can selectively let contacts show up in your list even when offline. All you need to do is right-click on such a person's contact entry and click "Show when Offline". Such people will then always be listed among your contacts even when offline.

Save your chat session

If you usually have multiple IM windows or tabs open, and have long-running conversation, you might find value in being able to save the state of your chat windows so you can resume the session after restarting your computer, or updating Pidgin, or after an inadvertent crash. This functionality is expertly provided by the 'SessionSave' plug-in. Download this plug-in from <http://somewhere.fscked.org/proj/sessionsave/>

Start Pidgin on Windows startup

This seems like a pretty simple request, and Pidgin seems like the kind of application you'd want to have running when you start your computer. However, when you check out the Pidgin preferences, you'll find such an option is curiously missing. The option is there though, just not where you'd expect.

Pidgin includes a 'Windows Pidgin Options' plug-in which offers a number of important Windows-specific options. It's here that you can enable and configure Pidgin to start auto-

matically when you start your computer.

Dock Pidgin to a side of the screen

Want your chat list to always be visible and available on screen? Pidgin supports such an option on Windows. This option, like the previous one, is found among the Windows Pidgin Options plug-in's configuration option.



Strangely, Pidgin needs a plug-in for this as well!

There you'll find an option for a "Dockable Buddy List". Once you enable this option, you'll be able to drag the Pidgin window to a side of the screen, and have it automatically dock there. What this means is that it will permanently take up that area of the screen, and other maximised windows will then only take up the remaining space.

Better formatting tools layout

If for some reason you like to change the formatting of your chat messages from time to time, you might like to have quick access to formatting tools. While these tools are available in Pidgin, they're by default grouped together under "Font". Luckily you can ungroup them by right-clicking on the formatting toolbar and clicking "Ungroup Items". This will expand the formatting toolbar and show all the tools you'll need.

Quickly search through your conversations, and shout

Imagine you're having a chat conversation with someone who